



Agent001 doesn't want you mistreating your camera! Here's a list of accessories for extending your life and getting more out of it!

Camera accessories

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Digital cameras have been in the market long enough and people have taken great interest in them. Accessories for cameras are meant for more than just maintenance. Here we look at the kinds of accessories available in the market and the money you will have to shell out for them.

For DSLRs, an additional lens is more than just an accessory. Cheaper DSLRs are usually bundled with a basic 18-55 mm lens and the very next requirement for amateur DSLR users is a zoom lens. For example, an 18-200 zoom lens is good both for wide-angle and telescopic shots. Third-party lenses are also available from manufacturers such as Tamron and Sigma. Check if your camera supports the lens you opt for. You also get 55-250 or 75-300 mm zoom lens. These are priced around the Rs. 10,000 mark. Image stabilisation usually costs a little more and prices can be slightly higher. For example, a 70-300 mm Sigma lens is priced around Rs. 9,000 and a 150-500 mm lens is approximately Rs. 52,000.

Filters are used to create certain effects without the need for further processing of the images. These are used in a way similar to lenses and are fitted atop the existing lens. UV filters and polarising filters help improve image contrasts, and a UV filter is needed at high altitude in the mountains. A neutral filter is often used simply to protect the lens from contact or damage and can also protect from dust and accidental fingerprints on the lens. Most of the basic filters range from Rs. 500 to Rs. 2,000. It's a good idea to have a basic filter that can help protect the lens without adding unnecessary colouration or distortion to the image.

A tripod is a must-have for every photography enthusiast. It helps to keep the camera stable so you don't end up with blurry images due to jittery hands. The size of a tripod isn't as important as its quality. Tripods can be relatively cheap and you can buy small compact ones from well-known brands such as Vivitar and Manfrotto for between Rs. 1,300 to Rs. 3,000. These are good for

picnics or hikes. With it all folded up, they can easily fit into a back pack. For the more professional, heavy-duty tripods, keep aside at least Rs. 5,000 to Rs. 10,000 for high-end kit from brands such as Benro. Monopods are cheaper and can be bought for Rs. 2,500 to Rs. 5,000 or so. Watch out for cheap plastic tripods. Carbon fibre tripods are rigid, and not as heavy to carry. Metal tripods are best left in the studio.

DSLR owners will always have a few complaints about the performance of the flash on their cameras. They're generally too weak and aren't easily controlled. Flash kits are available for different camera makes. A basic flashgun such as the Nikon SB400 is under Rs. 6,000, whereas the more superior SB600 is priced around Rs. 12,000. The advantages these bring are better control using the display on the flash unit, more power, faster charging and greater flexibility in positioning the flash. Each brand has its own set of compatible flash units that can be mounted on the cameras; prices vary.

A carry pouch helps in carrying your camera without damaging it. The cost of a pouch is really low and good ones for a point-and-shoot camera under Rs. 500. A slightly larger handbag with sections to keep a battery charger and other bits will cost you somewhere between Rs. 1,000 and Rs. 3,000 for brands such as Lowepro. Those who want to go out on outings for shooting should invest in complete bags with provisions for the flash, batteries, extra lens, a laptop and even a tripod. Models start from around Rs. 3,000 and go up to as high as Rs. 15,000.

Like any other expensive electronic product, cleaning and maintaining cameras is a must. One of the first things to buy for the lens and the LCD display is a lint-free micro-fibre cloth and/or a lipstick-style lens brush. Cost range in the hundreds of Rupees. A small hand-powered air blower that costs around Rs. 15 is also worth keeping in your carry bag to blow off loose dust from the crevices.

Film cameras used up film rolls, but when it comes to digital cameras, battery consumption is significant; especially, when you're clicking with your flash turned on. On a typical charge, it's possible to take over 150 to 200 photos on a standard point-and-shoot camera. Buy additional Li-ion batteries that are compatible with your camera. For a DSLR, a power pack costs around Rs. 1,000 for entry-level model and around Rs. 2,000 for the higher-end.

With AA batteries, you can always put in a new set and continue shooting. AA batteries are easy to find if you run out of charge. Uniross and Sanyo's Eneloop rechargeable batteries are known to charge quickly and don't discharge for long periods. Although slightly expensive compared to other rechargeable batteries, they still make a good buy in the long run. Expect to pay around Rs. 600 to Rs. 800 for a two-battery set and a charger.

Memory cards are cheap and for a point-and-shoot, a 2 GB standard SD memory card from Sandisk or Kingston is nothing more than Rs. 600. Sony's proprietary memory cards can be costly. Sandisk also manufactures MemoryStick Pro Duo cards for use with Sony cameras. A 2 GB Sony MS card costs Rs. 1,050 and a 4 GB one is available for Rs. 1,799. Most DSLRs also use SD cards, but it's a good idea to go in for the high capacity SD (SDHC) cards. A 4 GB SDHC card can be bought for around Rs. 2,000 and an 8 GB one for around Rs. 3,200. Some cameras use CompactFlash cards. This format is a little bulkier than standard SDHC cards, but there are high-performance CF cards from Sandisk - Extreme III and Extreme IV. The price of a Sandisk Extreme IV 4 GB CF card is around Rs. 3,000 and Rs. 6,050 for an 8 GB card. Sandisk Extreme III CF cards are around 20 to 30 per cent cheaper depending on the capacity. ■

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